

Memo

To: Dr. Derek G. Ross, Dr. Stewart Whittemore, and Dr. Susan Youngblood

From: V. Jasey Herrington

Re: SAP Study Meta-Analysis

Date: January 17th, 2026

Audience and Purpose

Making Sense of SAP: Heuristic Analysis of Federal Aid Communication at Four Alabama Universities was developed in ENGL 7010 Technical Communication: Issues and Approaches as an applied research project examining how higher education institutions communicate Satisfactory Academic Progress (SAP) policies and appeal procedures to students. My intended primary audience are institutional stakeholders responsible for designing and implementing student-facing policy documents. I recognize that a secondary audience could include researchers in higher education, technical communication, and other academic professionals interested in plain language, accessibility, and educational equity. The purpose of the project was to identify usability and accessibility gaps in SAP communication and to demonstrate how practitioner-informed, student-centered design can reduce those ethical barriers in high-stakes administrative contexts.

Goals and Editing Process

I served as the sole researcher and designer for this study, using a heuristic created through collaboration with an AI tool based on best practices. I collected the institutional documents and synthesized the findings. Drawing on my professional experience as an academic advisor, I approached this evaluation of SAP communication as a form of technical communication that requires translation, mediation, and linguistic sensitivity. I conducted a mixed-methods analysis of SAP materials from four Alabama universities (Auburn, University of Alabama, University of

North Alabama, and Alabama State University) and compared them to a practitioner-developed resource guide from the University of North Carolina- Chapel Hill.

The analysis followed a three step process: initial surface scan, application of a weighted plain language rubric, and cross-institutional comparison. This multi-step approach allowed me to pair qualitative analysis with quantitative scoring.

The primary goal of this study was to examine how SAP policies, although federally mandated, vary widely in clarity, accessibility, and usability based on institutional discretion. A secondary goal was to prioritize SAP communication as an issue of linguistic equity, particularly for first-generation, low-income, and transfer students who rely disproportionately on federal financial aid. My interest in accessibility, literacy development, and plain language informed my attention to jargon and undefined terminology.

The heuristic was grounded in plain language principles and included categories such as Findability, Appeal Process Clarity, Accessibility, and Institutional Support Resources. Those categories were then intentionally weighted to reflect real-world priorities (based on an assumed audience) rather than compliance-centered concerns. Findings revealed that while most institutions clearly communicated SAP rules, they consistently failed to provide actionable, student-focused guidance for deadlines and appeals.

Theories

This project draws on the technical communication idea that administrative documents can serve as rhetorical artifacts with real world consequences (Salvo, 2001; Spinuzzi, 2005). Usability theory (Nielsen, 2009), plain language principles, and UDL principles informed both the analysis and recommendations. Additionally, advising scholarship (Lowenstein, 2005) shaped the idea that educational professionals, similarly to technical communicators, are uniquely positioned to assist in policy development and communication.

Works Cited

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Salvo, M. J. (2001). Ethics of engagement: User-centered design and rhetorical methodology. *Technical Communication Quarterly*, 10(3), 273–290.

Spinuzzi, C. (2005). The methodology of participatory design. *Technical Communication*, 52(2), 163–174.